Where others run far when they hear bees buzzing, Gajanan Bhalerao runs towards them. They have been his childhood friends since the time he was growing up in Sawana in Maharashtra's Hingoli district, climbing trees to hunt for beehives, squeezing the nectar out of them and licking the honey off his fingers. If they stung him, Bhalerao did not seem to notice, so focused was he on the sweet reward of his pursuit.

FACT SHEET

Name of company: Kisan Madhumakshika Farm

What they do: Educate farmers on the importance of bees in the food cycle

Founded in: 2007

Annual turnover: Rs 9-10 lakh

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>
> GAJANAN BHALERAO

It would have remained a fond childhood memory had Bhalerao not joined a transport company at the age of 16 and encountered bee boxes while driving through the towns and villages of Jhalawar and Kota in Rajasthan. "I saw bee boxes for the first time and asked people about them. That's when I understood the importance of the insect on our farms," says Bhalerao.

The bug never left him even though it would be a while before Bhalerao dedicated himself to beekeeping. In the interim, he would train at the Khadi and Village Industries Commission and the Central Bee Research and Training Institute, Pune. Finally, in 2007, he decided to start his own bee-keeping business.

That was 18 years ago. Today, his life partner Madhuri is also his business partner, attending to the task of drawing and processing the honey and selling it under their brand, Kisan Madhumakshika Farm. The couple travel from farm to farm, their belongings—a tent, basic utensils and 500 bee boxes—piled onto their truck, chasing changing crops and seasons. In the monsoon, they camp in the millet farms of Malegaon to escape the heavy rains in hometown Nashik. Then, it's the pomegranate and guava farms of Maharashtra and the ajwain fields in Chittorgarh. In winter, they make home in the sprawling mustard field country that spans from Shri Mahaveerji in Rajasthan's Karauli district to the Etawah-Mathura stretch in UP. "We travel as per the crop," says Bhalerao. Once the 30-day pollination cycle is over, the couple and their boxes move to the next farm. "With pollination by bees, farm produce increases by almost 50 per cent," he says. "They are the best pollinators and extremely valuable in our food chain."

The bees have become a lifeline not just for Bhalerao but also for the 80,000+ farmers he's worked with over the past 18 years. Bhalerao urges farmers to steer clear of pesticides, which kill the bees. "Rampant use of pesticides has brought down the population of bees by 70 per cent over the past 20 years," he says. The fall in their natural population has fuelled a rise in apiculture. "If there are no bees, the planet won't survive," he says. "If bees die, humans will be wiped out in no time."

Bhalerao is also inspired by the work ethic of the humble *Apis melifera*. "The worker bees are busy for 11 hours, 53 minutes every day, travelling a maximum of 2.5 km. They cannot live in temperatures exceeding 36 degrees Celsius. Each box can house only one queen who lives for around three years," he tells you. Making new boxes is a meticulous task; larvae are carefully transplanted into a new box to grow and a queen introduced. The vocation has served Bhalerao well. "We have married off four daughters through the money earned by bee-keeping," he says. "It's a good business if you genuinely love and understand bees," he says.

And love them he does. You won't find Bhalerao in gloves or protective gear except a net over his face while handling his bee boxes. The bee bites on his hands he dismisses as an "occupational hazard". A buzzing bee is not a warning sign but music to Bhalerao's ears. ■